

WHAT IT IS • WHO PAYS • WHY IT WORKS

The thing I'm building, explained in plain English.

Photography lighting is hard. Most people who try to copy a great photo end up guessing. NGW takes the guessing out. This document explains what it actually does, who pays money for it, and how that could turn into a real business — without using a single word from a finance textbook.

§ 01 What is this thing?

The simplest way to say it: **NGW is Shazam, but for photo lighting**. A photographer sees an image they love — maybe a magazine cover, maybe a friend's shot — and asks the question every photographer asks: "**how did they light that?**" NGW answers it.

LIKE...

Shazam for music: it listens to a song and tells you what it is. **NGW** looks at a photo and tells you how the light was set up — where the lamps were, what kind they were, what they were bouncing off.

WHAT YOU PUT IN

A photo. Could be a magazine page, a phone screenshot, a reference from a shoot the photographer wants to recreate. One image.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

A reconstruction: the lights drawn on a diagram, what type they were, what was attached to them, and a step-by-step guide a photographer can use to **actually rebuild the shot** in their own studio.

Why this is hard

Photo lighting leaves clues — the shape of a shadow on a cheek, the highlight in someone's eye, where the brightness falls off across a forehead. A trained eye can read these, but it takes years. NGW reads them automatically, in a few seconds, and explains its answer in language a photographer can act on.

The system is careful about being honest. If a photo is ambiguous — say a shadow could mean two different things — it **says so** instead of guessing. Photographers trust tools that admit when they don't know.

§ 02 Who actually pays for this?

Not everyone who likes photography. The buyer is specific: a **working photographer** — someone who gets paid to take photos for a living. They shoot portraits, fashion, products, beauty. They have studio lights they own or rent, and they care about lighting the way a chef cares about a stove.

LIKE...

A working photographer is to NGW what a **professional chef** is to a really good knife. A home cook might admire it, but the chef is the one who buys it and uses it every day.

PAYS THE MOST

Studios & teams

A small studio with 2–6 people sharing references, kit lists, and reconstructed setups. They pay for the higher tier because they need to collaborate, share, and process more.

PAYS THE MIDDLE

Solo working photographer

One photographer, paying clients, owns lighting kit. Uses NGW the way an accountant uses tax software — daily, professionally, expense it. **This is the main customer.**

DOESN'T PAY

Hobbyist & learner

Loves photography, doesn't bill for it. Uses the free version, learns from the reference library, tells working photographer friends about it. They are the word-of-mouth, not the wallet.

Why would a working photographer pay?

Because a single solved problem is worth more than a month of subscription. If NGW saves a photographer one reshoot — one bad-lighting day that didn't have to happen — the tool has paid for itself for the year. That's the math working photographers do in their heads.

It also makes them faster. A 20-minute "what light did they use?" exercise becomes 30 seconds, and the answer is something they can actually build, not a guess.

§ 03 How it makes money

It's a **subscription** — same shape as Netflix or Spotify. You sign up, you pay every month, you get to use the tool. Stop paying and you go back to the free version. There are three levels.

LIKE...

A **gym membership**. Free tier = guest pass. Pro tier = standard membership. Studio tier = team / family plan with extras.

FREE

\$0 / month

Three free analyses. Lets a curious photographer prove to themselves that the tool actually works before paying anything.

PRO • THE MAIN ONE

\$39 / month

Unlimited analyses, the full set of professional features. This is the version a working photographer would actually buy. About the price of a nice meal out — per month.

STUDIO

\$59 / month

Everything in Pro, plus team sharing, batch processing, and priority support. For small studios who need to collaborate.

THE TRIAL

Every new user gets a **14-day free trial** of the Pro features. **No credit card**. If they like it, they pay. If they don't, they go back to the free version with no awkward billing.

Same shape as Netflix's first month: try it without commitment, decide if it's worth keeping.

PAY YEARLY, SAVE TWO MONTHS

If a photographer pays for the whole year up front, they get roughly **two months free**. This is the same trick phone carriers use: yearly customers are more committed and cheaper to keep, so they get a discount.

§ 04 What could this become?

Out of every 100 people who visit the NGW website, only a small group ends up paying. That's normal — every subscription business looks like this. The question is **how many**.



MODELED These percentages are our planning targets, not measured reality. The actual numbers replace these once enough real photographers have used it.

Three sizes of the future

If we keep doing what we're doing, here are three honest pictures of what the business could look like by the end of year one:



§ 05 Why this could work • and what could go wrong

Every business has reasons it could work and reasons it might not. Here's the honest version of both sides for NGW.

Why this could work

- + **The problem is real and specific.** Photographers ask "how did they light that?" every day. NGW answers a question they're already asking.
- + **The buyer has money and routine.** Working photographers already pay for tools — software, equipment, plugins. Adding one more \$39 line is a normal decision for them, not a leap.
- + **It gets better with use.** Every photo analyzed makes the system smarter. The product compounds — early users help future users.
- + **It's honest about uncertainty.** When a photo is ambiguous, NGW says so. Photographers trust tools that admit limits more than tools that bluff. That trust is the long-term moat.

What could go wrong

- **One bad answer in public.** If a high-profile photographer posts a NGW answer that's clearly wrong, trust takes a hit. The fix: keep being honest about what the system doesn't know.
- **The "AI tax" gets too expensive.** Every analysis costs us a few cents of computing. If we're not careful, the bill grows faster than the subscriptions.
- **A bigger company copies it.** Adobe or someone like them launches a similar feature. The defense is depth — our reference library, the specificity of our photographer-language, and a brand photographers actually trust.
- **Niche too narrow to grow big.** Working photographers are a real market but not a huge one. The bigger story is the same engine extended into adjacent crafts: film, video, even painting reference.

THE SHORT VERSION, IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER ONE THING

A working photographer asks "how did they light that?" NGW answers it for \$39 a month. The product gets smarter with every photo it sees. The honesty about uncertainty is the brand. The growth comes from photographers telling other photographers. **That's the whole pitch.**